

SHARAD SAXENA



trainer-cycle routine. Today, there are more males going in for muscle sculpting exercise routines than those on the machines. Most of them want to take advantage of the several scientific methods available for shaping up the body.

But self-image is just a starter. "There's no end to the compulsions that make men seek a cosmetic procedure," says Dr Milind Wagh, consultant plastic aesthetic and reconstructive surgeon with the Hiranandani and Bhatia hospitals in Mumbai. "From job interviews to marriage, pressure from peers and the opposite sex to the desire to follow the ways of a much-admired Bollywood hero." Choudhury agrees: "The best candidates are those who wish to simply improve their appearance. They are usually satisfied after a surgery and their self-esteem and confidence levels visibly shoot up. Then there are those who come from the world of showbiz, where appearance counts for all. There is another category: of men who blame their present physical appearance for all personal misfortunes. Men in unhappy relationships also use surgery to save their failing ties. About 3-5 per cent men suffer from minimal deformity but have disproportionate concerns about the way they look.

Everyone is into instant abs and the SRK look. But body obsession doesn't

really pay. It's well documented that for women, it often leads to extreme dieting and exercise. How widespread are eating disorders among men? Hard to say. Men are notoriously hesitant to seek psychological treatment, particularly for body-image disorders. "Young men with poor body image and high drive for muscularity often carry the burden of low self-esteem, anxiety, and depression," warns Saha. In addition, they may be more at risk of abusing anabolic steroids, the health consequences of which range from coronary heart disease risk, to kidney and liver damage, liver cancer, high blood pressure, reduced immune system functioning to even infertility.

The urge for 'The Body', however, is compelling enough for men to cough up whopping sums in pursuit of their personal look. With technology reaching new levels of sophistication, a third-generation ultrasonic liposuction machine may leave the patient with a bill of Rs 1.2 lakh. But the spiralling costs are balanced out by state-of-the-art technology and easy access. "The advent of finer suture materials, refinement in surgical techniques, the availability of good quality plastic surgery implants and simplification of surgical techniques have made a difference in the surgical outcomes," says Venkatesh. Moreover, most cosmetic body procedures today are done as day care procedures. "A lunch time nose job and a tea time liposuction and body contouring are the makeover procedures of the present day," he says.

In a way, men have arrived late to the party. Beauty ceased to be a myth for women ever since millions sat glued to television sets to watch the crowning of Sushmita Sen and Aishwarya Rai in world beauty pageants in the '90s. "Up until the '70s, beauty contests used to be peripheral affairs, only covered by specialised women's magazines," wrote Madhu Kishwar, the editor of *Manushi*, in her 1995 essay, *When India Missed The Universe*. Today Miss India clones—narrow waist, long legs, narrow hips, glossy hair, rosebud mouth, spaghetti straps—are everywhere. In glossy ads,

The Age Slab

The age spectrum for cosmetic surgery procedures (in years)

17-25

- Enlarged breasts
- Scar removal
- Nose job

25-35

- Face and body contouring

35-45

- Making the chin more prominent
- Body contouring, abdominal liposuction, abdominoplasty, abdominal etching

45+

- Lines and wrinkles, especially around the eyes
- Face Rejuvenation

All age groups

- Enlarged breasts
- Making the chin more prominent
- Nose job